Fate-Engineered Oxidative Hair Dye Chemistry: Precursors and Chromophores Designed to Be Stable in Hair, Cleavable on Skin, and Degradable in Wastewater

Research Proposal (no experimental results reported)
Domain: Cosmetic Chemistry, Green Chemistry, Fiber Science, Toxicology

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Abstract

Permanent oxidative hair dyes depend on small aromatic amines that penetrate the cortex and couple into wash-fast chromophores. Their hazards are skin sensitization and persistent effluent. Existing improvements address one problem at a time: ME-PPD lowers sensitization, amino-acid alkalizers replace ammonia, and melanin-mimetic coatings avoid aromatic amines but lack shade range. We propose fate engineering: designing the precursor and the coupled dye so each behaves differently in three environments. In hair, the molecule persists and gives 28-shampoo fastness. On skin, an esterase-labile group converts unreacted precursor into a polar, less haptenating species. In wastewater, a trigger link breaks the chromophore for biodegradation. We describe a screening funnel of 5–8 cleavable PPD analogues against ME-PPD, with in-vitro sensitization assays, coupling kinetics, tress performance and OECD 301B testing. Arginine-based alkali and ME-PPD are used as the benchmark, not as the contribution. This is a research proposal; no experimental results are reported.

Keywords: oxidative hair dye, PPD analogues, ME-PPD, fate engineering, esterase-labile, wash-fastness, OECD 301B, sensitization

Contents

1 Introduction **3**

1.1 Why oxidative dyes are hard to replace 3

1.2 Scope of this proposal 3

2 Prior art and gap **3**

3 Research question and thesis **4**

4 Objectives and hypotheses **4**

5 Design concept **4**

6 Experimental plan (12 months) **5**

6.1 Phase 1 (months 1–4): synthesis and in-vitro 5

6.2 Phase 2 (months 5–9): tresses 5
6.3 Phase 3 (months 10–12): fate testing 5

7 Expected results and success criteria **5**

8 Limitations **5**

9 IP statement **6**

10 Sustainability and safety framework **6**

11 Risks and mitigations **6**

12 Future work **6**

13 Conclusion **7**

1 Introduction

1.1 Why oxidative dyes are hard to replace

Over 50% of women and a growing share of men in Europe, North America, the Middle East, and Asia use oxidative hair color. The permanent segment dominates value because only it covers grey durably in a single step.

Its mechanism imposes three linked requirements:

1. **Swell and open:** At pH 9–11, cuticle scales lift and the cortex swells so monomers can enter.
2. **Penetrate small, trap large:** Monomeric precursors (MW ∼100–150 Da) diffuse into the cortex. Peroxide oxidizes them with couplers into dimers and polymers (MW > 500 Da) too large to diffuse out. This size-exclusion trap is permanence.
3. **Couple to color:** Primary intermediate + coupler → indo dye chromophore. PPD/PTD-based couplings remain unmatched for shade gamut and wash/light fastness.

Green constraints pull against each step: lower pH reduces swelling and penetration; replacing small aromatic amines removes in-situ polymerization; weaker oxidation reduces coupling and lift; and a dye designed to biodegrade appears to contradict wash-fastness.

1.2 Scope of this proposal

This proposal does not claim a complete green permanent system, a new alkali, a new oxidant, or a full shade chart. Its scope is narrower: the design of the precursor and the coupled dye so that conditional stability resolves the fastness-versus-fate trade-off. Alkali and oxidant optimization, clinical testing, and salon trials are explicitly out of scope (see Section 6).

2 Prior art and gap

Table 1: Prior art and what it does not cover

Area	Prior art	Not covered
Amino-acid alkali	Arginine/lysine alkalizer; arginine demi-permanents	Permanent performance, effluent fate
Low-sensitizing precursor	ME-PPD; commercial use	Cross-elicitation; no degradation design
Resorcinol-free	Resorcinol-free patents	Precursor persistence
Melanin-mimetic	DHI/DHICA; polydopamine	Narrow gamut; surface coatings
Encapsulated oxidant	Encapsulated peroxide	Not tied to dye design

Details: amino-acid alkali—US 10639257; US 11497698; WO 1997/004739. Low-sensitizing precursor—Goebel et al. 2014. Resorcinol-free—US 11517514. Melanin-mimetic—Brown et al. 1989; US 5346509; RSC Adv. 2019, 2021. Encapsulated oxidant—US 4844711; US 5053051; US 10653592.

ME-PPD is the closest prior art for a lower-sensitizing precursor and is therefore the benchmark here. It still gives approximately 30% cross-elicitation in PPD-allergic subjects (Blömeke et al.

2015; Kock et al. 2016) and was not designed for environmental degradation. Amino-acid alkalizers address odor and volatility, not precursor fate. Melanin-mimetic systems avoid aromatic amines but cover a narrow gamut and behave mainly as surface coatings.

Gap statement: "To our knowledge, no published work designs oxidative-dye precursors and chromophores with distinct, intentional fates in hair, on skin and in wastewater. This is the focus of the present proposal."

3 Research question and thesis

Research question (RQ): Can an oxidative dye precursor be designed to be stable in hair, esterase-labile on skin, and its coupled dye cleavable in wastewater, without losing coupling kinetics or wash-fastness relative to ME-PPD?

Thesis: Single-property substitutions have not resolved the performance-versus-safety trade-off. Conditional stability, meaning stable in one environment and labile in another, is the design principle that can.

4 Objectives and hypotheses

O1: Synthesize 5–8 PPD analogues with cleavable groups (ester, carbonate, hindered amide).
O2: Show coupling kinetics within ±25% of ME-PPD with m-aminophenol-type couplers [TO MEASURE].
O3: Show esterase half-life on skin-like models of ≤60 min and sensitization potency (DPRA, KeratinoSens, h-CLAT) no worse than ME-PPD [TO MEASURE].
O4: Show 28-shampoo fastness $\Delta E^*_{ab} \leq 3$ against an ME-PPD control on natural and white tresses.
O5: Show ≥ 60% primary degradation of the coupled dye within 28 days under OECD 301B-type conditions [TO MEASURE].

H1: A sterically hindered ester survives 30–45 min at pH 9–10 inside hair but is cleaved by skin esterases.
H2: The cleaved carboxylate or alcohol product is more polar and less able to haptenate proteins.
H3: A trigger link placed away from the chromophore does not shift color or fastness.

5 Design concept

This section replaces any four-pillar system description. The contribution is the precursor and chromophore design only.

- **Core:** a PPD or ME-PPD scaffold that keeps the oxidation potential needed for coupling.
- **Cleavable side chain:** an ester or carbonate at the 2-position or on an N-alkyl group, tuned by steric hindrance.
- **Trigger link in the chromophore:** a link that is stable at pH 9 in hair but breaks under enzymatic or pH-shift conditions in effluent.
- **Baseline system:** arginine-based alkali and conventional 6% peroxide for the controls. Alkali and oxidant optimization is future work.

Key risk, stated openly: esters can hydrolyze at pH 9–10 before they reach the cortex. The screening funnel must test stability in the formulation first. Candidates that hydrolyze in the tint base before application fail early, regardless of esterase behavior.

6 Experimental plan (12 months)

6.1 Phase 1 (months 1–4): synthesis and in-vitro

- Synthesize analogues; confirm structure and purity.
- UV-Vis / LC-MS coupling kinetics vs. ME-PPD.
- Ester stability at pH 9–10 in formulation-like buffer.
- Esterase assay on skin-like models.
- DPRA, KeratinoSens, h-CLAT; cytotoxicity (3T3 NRU).

6.2 Phase 2 (months 5–9): tresses

- Substrates: natural, bleached, and 100% white tresses.
- Color yield (CIELAB), 28-shampoo fastness, light fastness.
- Tensile strength and combing force.
- Use $n \geq 5$ tresses per condition, with controls (ME-PPD dye, PTD dye) and statistical tests (ANOVA with post-hoc).

6.3 Phase 3 (months 10–12): fate testing

- OECD 301B on precursors and coupled dyes separately.
- LC-MS identification of breakdown products.
- Screening-level aquatic toxicity.

Out of scope: clinical HRIPT and salon trials (listed as future work), and any claim of Level 10 lift.

7 Expected results and success criteria

Notes: control is ME-PPD / PTD dye as specified in Section 6. Coupling rate is normalized to ME-PPD. Dye primary degradation is measured under OECD 301B-type conditions at 28 days.

8 Limitations

- Ester stability at alkaline pH may force a narrower design window.
- In-vitro sensitization assays do not replace clinical testing.
- New precursors need a full regulatory dossier, which is outside this scope.
- Lift beyond 1–2 levels and platinum blonde are not targeted.

Table 2: Success criteria vs. ME-PPD / PTD control

Metric	Control	Target
Coupling rate	1.0 (ref)	0.75–1.25
28-shampoo ΔE^*_{ab}	measured	≤ 3 (≤ 4 max)
Grey coverage, white	measured	$\geq 95\%$
Sensitization in-vitro	ME-PPD value	not worse
Dye degradation, 28 d	$\sim$0%	$\geq 60\%$
Tensile loss	measured	not worse

9 IP statement

"Related patents on amino-acid alkalizers, ME-PPD, resorcinol-free dyes and encapsulated oxidants exist. The present work aims to claim the cleavable-precursor and trigger-link chromophore concept. A freedom-to-operate review is required before commercialization."

10 Sustainability and safety framework

- Non-animal sensitization battery only (OECD TG 442C/D/E); no new animal testing proposed.
- Ready biodegradability assessed by OECD 301B on precursors and coupled dyes separately, not on whole formula alone.
- LCA screening follows ISO 14040 logic (cradle-to-rinse comparison vs. ME-PPD control) without claiming a full ISO-compliant LCA in 12 months.
- Green chemistry audit limited to what this scope controls: atom economy of the analogue synthesis, E-factor of the screening route, and removal of the persistent-chromophore endpoint.

11 Risks and mitigations

Table 3: Risks and mitigations

Risk	Likelihood	Mitigation
Ester hydrolyzes at pH 9–10	High	Hindered ester; stability gate first
Coupling rate drops	Medium	Keep PPD core; 5–8 funnel
In-vitro sensitization equivocal	Medium	Three-assay battery + esterase $t_{1/2}$
Trigger link shifts color	Medium	Link off-chromophore; CIELAB gate
301B pass precursor, fail dye	Medium	Test both separately; redesign trigger

12 Future work

- Arginine-alkali and low-dose oxidant optimization around the lead precursor.
- Clinical HRIPT and salon half-head evaluation after in-vitro and tress gates pass.

- Full shade-chart extension beyond the m-aminophenol-type coupler set.
- Full regulatory dossier and ISO 14040/14044 LCA at pilot scale.

13 Conclusion

Permanent oxidative dyes persist because small aromatic amines couple into wash-fast chromophores, and persist where they should not: on skin as haptens and in effluent as stable aromatics. This proposal tests whether conditional stability can separate those fates: stable in hair for 28-shampoo fastness, esterase-labile on skin, and trigger-cleavable in wastewater. The test is comparative against ME-PPD at every gate (kinetics, sensitization in-vitro, tress performance, and OECD 301B degradation), with negative outcomes defined in advance.

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[11] US 5346509—melanin-precursor dyeing.

[12] US 4844711; US 5053051; US 10653592—encapsulated oxidants.

[13] US 10952946.

[14] OECD TG 301B (ready biodegradability); OECD TG 442C/D/E (DPRA, KeratinoSens, h-CLAT).

[15] ISO 14040—life cycle assessment principles.